Workplace Conduct Policy

Policy Summary & Knowledge Check

Authority	Board of Directors
Date Ratified	February 2, 2024
Next Review Date	February 2027
Previous Amendments	May 28, 2013

Policy Summary

This policy establishes expectations for professional, respectful conduct among USC Staff and volunteers, both within USC spaces and at USC functions elsewhere, in order to maintain a dynamic workplace free from interpersonal conflict and discrimination. It covers general conduct principles, interpersonal interactions, workplace environment standards, and the procedural authority for related sub-procedures.

Key Takeaways

- Governs the conduct of USC Staff in relation to other Staff, volunteers, and the workplace environment, including USC functions held outside the USC Main Office space; it applies to volunteers where specified.
- All Staff and volunteers must treat people equally and fairly, respect due process and equal opportunity, act with integrity and guard against conflicts of interest, report fraud, misconduct, and corruption, and comply with applicable USC or UWO codes of conduct.
- All Staff have an obligation to ensure everyone is treated with dignity and respect and is not exposed to harassment or discrimination as prohibited by the Human Rights Code; a respectful tone and language must be maintained regardless of the subject matter being discussed.
- Personal insults, derogatory language, and any conduct, communication, or gestures that would constitute violence or the threat of violence — as defined in the Discrimination, Harassment and Violence Prevention Policy — must be avoided at all times.
- Staff and volunteers must refrain from compromising the USC's political impartiality as a corporation, keep personal work areas and common areas clean and professional, respect others' workspaces and belongings, and use the workplace environment for professional purposes only.
- Further Procedures needed to implement this policy are established and amended by the Human Resources Department, must stay within the scope of this policy, must be ratified by the Board of Directors before taking effect, and can be repealed by a resolution of Council.

Knowledge Check

5 situational questions to check understanding of this policy. An answer key follows on the next page.

Q1. A staff member makes a public comment that could be seen as compromising the USC's political impartiality. Does this policy address this?

A. Yes — Staff and volunteers must refrain from comments or actions that compromise the USC's political impartiality.
B. It's only restricted for Executive Members.
C. It's only restricted during election periods.
D. No, political commentary isn't addressed by this policy.

Q2. Two staff members are having a heated disagreement about a work process. What tone does the policy require they maintain?

A. Any tone is acceptable as long as the issue gets resolved.

B. A respectful tone and respectful language, regardless of the subject matter being discussed.

C. Formal written communication only, with no verbal discussion.

D. Silence until a manager is present to intervene.

Q3. Who is responsible for establishing and amending further Procedures needed to implement this policy?

A. External legal counsel.

B. Any individual staff member, at their discretion.

C. The Human Resources Department, subject to ratification by the Board of Directors.

D. The Gazette.

Q4. Does this policy apply to interactions at a USC-organized event held outside the Main Office space?

A. Only if a manager is present at the event.

B. Only for events lasting more than one day.

C. No, only conduct inside the Main Office is covered.

D. Yes — it applies to interactions of Staff and USC representatives at USC functions outside the Main Office space.

Q5. An employee uses a colleague's belongings without permission in a shared workspace. What does the policy say?

A. Individuals shall respect the work spaces of others and refrain, wherever possible, from using others' belongings without permission.

B. This is only an issue if the item is damaged.

C. Shared workspaces have no expectations around personal belongings.

D. This is acceptable as long as the items are returned.

Answer Key

Q1: A — Section 4.1 states Staff and volunteers shall refrain from making comments or performing actions that compromise the political impartiality of the USC.

Q2: B — Section 3.2 requires individuals to maintain a respectful tone and use respectful language in all interpersonal interactions regardless of the subject matter.

Q3: C — Sections 5.1 and 5.1.3 state Procedures are established and amended by Human Resources and must be ratified by the Board of Directors before taking effect.

Q4: D — Section 1.2 states this policy applies to interactions of Staff and USC representatives at USC functions outside of the USC Main Office space.

Q5: A — Section 4.4 states individuals shall respect the work spaces of others and refrain, wherever possible, from using others' belongings without permission, explicit or otherwise.